the needle has moved up in terms of its competitive position. It is a completely new hatch in the compact car segment,' he said.

The upgraded version received a much better response, with 3,000 bookings within a month of its launch, as compared to an average monthly sale of 1,400 Nanos in the previous year. Positioned as a 'smart city car', the AMT version of the GenX Nano received more attention than the manual version, with people queueing up at dealerships to try it out. But this enthusiasm was short-lived.

Many in Tata Motors doubted if Cyrus Mistry, who succeeded Ratan as Tata Group chairman in 2012, had the will and capacity to drive a project such as the Nano. Some opine that he did not do enough to take the project forward. His lack of enthusiasm in pursuing serious inquiries for Tata cars from cab companies Uber and Ola is often cited as an example.

There were definite prospects of both these companies placing large orders with Tata Motors. Bhavesh Aggarwal, CEO of Ola Cabs, had met Ratan and informed him that his company was ready to 'immediately acquire 10,000 Nanos and Indicas/Indigos from Tata Motors on outright purchase, lease or joint venture'. In addition, Ratan was also informed that the cab company had plans to procure 150,000 such vehicles on an annual basis. After receiving this proposal, on 31 August 2015, Ratan wrote to Mayank Pareek, president of the Passenger Vehicles Business Unit at Tata Motors, informing him that Aggarwal had met and briefed him about the requirement of Ola Cabs.

But the response from Tata Motors was unenthusiastic. It led Aggarwal to inform Ratan that Tata Motors had been very slow in responding to the request and that if it were not interested in working with Ola, he would take up a competitor's offer.

Pareek kept Mistry informed about the development. In turn, he was informed by Shailesh Chandra, assistant vice president of the group chairman's office, that Tata Motors had been in touch with Ola till June 2015 for a 'potential deal regarding purchase of about 8,000 Nanos and 6,000 Indicas in a period of three months'. But in the meantime, the company had also received a request from Uber for 120,000 Indicas and Indigos. In view of this, Chandra said that priority had to be accorded to the larger inquiry and Pareek was requested to 'understand their inability to respond fast to Ola'.